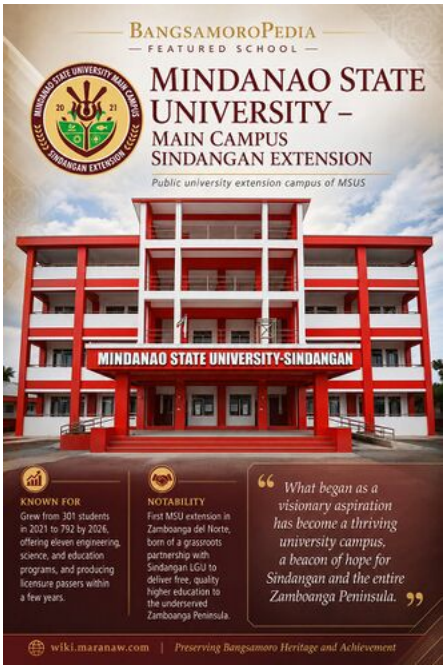
Mindanao State University – Main Campus Sindangan Extension

Mindanao State University – Main Campus Sindangan Extension (commonly called **MSU-MCSE**) is a public university extension campus of the Mindanao State University System, located in Barangay Balok, Sindangan, Zamboanga del Norte, Philippines. It stands as one of the youngest yet fastest-growing extension campuses in the MSU System, built through a partnership between the Local Government Unit (LGU) of Sindangan and MSU Main Campus in Marawi City. Since its establishment in 2021, MSU-MCSE has grown from a pioneering batch of 301 students into a campus of nearly 800 enrollees, offering programs in engineering, environmental science, fisheries, psychology, mathematics, statistics, and secondary education.

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Mindanao State University – Main Campus Sindangan Extension



Also Known As

MSU-MCSE

Established

March 22, 2021 (Board of Regents approval); inaugurated September 9, 2021

Type

Public university extension campus

Parent Institution

Mindanao State University System

Campus Director

Dr. Florencio D. Recoleto Jr.

Location

Brgy. Balok, Sindangan, Zamboanga del Norte, Philippines

Enrollment

792 students (2nd Semester, AY 2025–2026)

Academic Programs

11 degree programs across engineering, sciences, and education

Notability

The first MSU extension campus established in Zamboanga del Norte, born out of a grassroots partnership between the Sindangan local government and the MSU System to bring free, quality higher

Overview

MSU-MCSE was created to answer a long-standing need in Sindangan and its neighboring municipalities: access to free, quality tertiary education without having to travel far from home. As an extension of the MSU System, which was chartered to serve Muslim and Indigenous communities across the MINSUPALA (Mindanao-Sulu-Palawan) region, the campus carries forward that same mission while also opening its doors widely to the broader population of Zamboanga del Norte, including the Subanen communities native to the area. Today it offers eleven degree programs, supports a growing roster of licensed professionals among its graduates, and continues to expand its facilities and academic offerings year after year.

education to an underserved part of the Zamboanga Peninsula

Known For

Growing from 301 pioneering students in 2021 to 792 enrollees by 2026, offering eleven engineering, science, and education degree programs, and producing licensure exam passers within just a few years of opening its doors

Pull Quote

"What began as a visionary aspiration has become a thriving university campus, a beacon of hope for Sindangan and the entire Zamboanga Peninsula."

History and Founding

The story of MSU-MCSE traces back to the early days of Hon. Rosendo "Dodoy" S. Labadlabad's term as Municipal Mayor of Sindangan, which began in July 2019. Education was one of his top priorities from day one, with local leaders already dreaming of a homegrown institution of higher learning even before the idea had a name.

That dream took clearer shape in November 2019, when Mayor Labadlabad learned about the MSU Charter during a gathering he attended. Realizing that MSU's mandate to serve Muslim and Indigenous communities, including the Subanens of Zamboanga del Norte, aligned perfectly with what Sindangan needed, he began exploring the idea in earnest.

The real spark, though, came from a casual conversation. Former Sangguniang Bayan (SB) Member Hon. Floro "Dodong" S. Ricaborda of Titay, Zamboanga Sibugay, ran into Dr. Florencio "Anjun" D. Recoleto Jr., then Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs of MSU Main Campus, and Prof. Elpidio "Pids" S. Ricaborda, JD, while discussing an entirely different MSU extension project. Somewhere in that conversation came the question that changed everything: why not put up an MSU extension in Sindangan too?

From there, momentum built quickly. Mayor Labadlabad and Hon. Dodong Ricaborda rallied local officials such as SB Secretary Dr. El B. Jimenez, SB Member Hon. Jerome E. Ochavo, Municipal Administrator Mr. Jie Archie D. Reluya, CPA, Mr. Michael A. Masalta, and Municipal Health Officer Dr. Rex V. Samson, with strong backing from Vice Mayor Hon. Nilo Florentino "Boy" Z. Sy and the Sangguniang Bayan, which passed supportive resolutions to move things along.

On July 23, 2020, Mayor Labadlabad formally wrote to MSU System President Dr. Habib W. Macaayong to open discussions about establishing the extension campus. By August 12, 2020, the group, now joined by Hon. Congresswoman Glona G. Labadlabad (who later became Mayor of Sindangan herself), LGU Legal Officer Atty. Lunrey B. Bagor, and MSU officials including Vice President for Planning and Development Dr. Rasid M. Paca and Vice President for Academic Affairs Dr. Alma E. Berowa, met in Iligan City for the first exploratory talks with MSU's Deans and Department Chairs.

That December, the University issued Special Order No. 747-OP, Series of 2020, creating a Technical Working Committee (TWC) chaired by Dr. Paca, with Dr. Recoleto as Vice Chairperson. OVCAA Special Assistants Dr. Joel V. Araya, Dr. Alyanah G. Pantao, and Prof. Ian Randy F. Gallego handled the heavy lifting of preparing the feasibility study and supporting documents, work that paid off when the Academic Planning Committee approved the proposal on March 9, 2021.

The breakthrough moment arrived on March 22, 2021, when the MSU Board of Regents officially approved the creation of MSU-MCSE. A Memorandum of Agreement (MOA) between the LGU of Sindangan and MSU Main Campus followed on April 8, 2021, cementing the partnership. Soon after, Dr. Recoleto was designated as the campus's First Campus Director through a special order, with a six-year term as laid out in the MOA.

Institutional Development

Entrance exams came fast on the heels of the Board's approval. The MSU System Admission and Scholarship Examination (MSU-SASE) was held on March 28, 2021, followed by the MSU College Entrance Test (MSU-CET) on May 22 and July 10, 2021. Enrollment for the pioneering batch ran from July 21 to 30, 2021, at the Old Municipal Building of Sindangan, and 301 students made the cut across ten founding degree programs.

The campus held its first Flag Raising Ceremony on September 8, 2021, at the Misok Campus, followed the next day by its official inauguration at the Balok campus site and its first University Convocation, marking the true start of academic life at MSU-MCSE.

From there, growth has been steady and, at times, dramatic. By the Second Semester of AY 2024–2025, enrollment had climbed to 757 students. The campus celebrated its 4th Founding Anniversary on March 22, 2025, in partnership with the LGU of Sindangan, and just months later, on July 4, 2025, it held its historic First Pre-Commencement Exercises, presenting 113 pioneering graduates, five of them Magna Cum Laude and forty Cum Laude. These degrees were formally conferred at the 61st Commencement Exercises of MSU Main Campus in Marawi City on July 24, 2025.

By the Second Semester of AY 2025–2026, enrollment had grown further still, to 792 students across ten pioneering programs, with a new eleventh program (BSEd Mathematics) approved to start in AY 2026–2027.

Etymology

The name "Mindanao State University – Main Campus Sindangan Extension" reflects its administrative status as a satellite or extension campus of MSU Main Campus in Marawi City, rather than an independent chartered university. "MCSE" is simply shorthand built from "Main Campus Sindangan Extension," and it is this acronym, MSU-MCSE, that the campus and its community use in everyday reference.

Vision, Mission, and Core Values

While MSU-MCSE operates under the broader mandate of the Mindanao State University System, its guiding purpose has consistently centered on bringing accessible, quality, and free higher education closer to the people of Sindangan and the neighboring municipalities of Zamboanga del Norte, particularly underserved communities who would otherwise have to travel far for a college education. Its 5th Founding Anniversary theme, "MSU-MCSE at 5: Strengthening Connections, Sustaining Academic Excellence, and Advocating for Peace, Innovation, and Inclusive Education," captures much of what the campus continues to stand for: connection, excellence, peace, innovation, and inclusion.

Founders and Early Leadership

The founding of MSU-MCSE was very much a community effort. Key figures include:

- Hon. Rosendo "Dodoy" S. Labadlabad, Municipal Mayor of Sindangan, whose administration championed the establishment of the campus from the very beginning
- Hon. Floro "Dodong" S. Ricaborda, whose conversation with MSU officials sparked the idea
- Dr. Florencio "Anjun" D. Recoleto Jr., then Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs of MSU Main Campus, who became the campus's First Campus Director
- Prof. Elpidio "Pids" S. Ricaborda, JD, OVCAA Special Assistant, later Special Assistant to the Campus Director
- Dr. Rasid M. Paca, RME, JD, then Vice President for Planning and Development, who chaired the Technical Working Committee
- Dr. Alma E. Berowa, then Vice President for Academic Affairs
- Dr. Habib W. Macaayong, MSU System President at the time of the initial talks
- Hon. Congresswoman Glona G. Labadlabad, later Mayor of Sindangan, who supported the campus from its earliest exploratory discussions
- Vice Mayor Hon. Nilo Florentino "Boy" Z. Sy and the members of the Sangguniang Bayan, who provided legislative backing through supportive resolutions

Historical Development

The campus's growth since 2021 has moved along several fronts at once: enrollment, academic programs, faculty and staff, research culture, and institutional partnerships. What started as a ten-program offering with 301 pioneering students has, within five years, become an eleven-program campus with nearly 800 students, a growing base of licensed professional graduates, and a deepening relationship with both the MSU System Administration and the LGU of Sindangan.

Campus and Location

MSU-MCSE is situated in Barangay Balok, Sindangan, Zamboanga del Norte, with academic operations also held at the Misok Campus. Enrollment activities in recent years have made use of venues such as the Sindangan Cultural and Sports Complex, while the Office of the Campus Director has operated out of the 2nd Floor of the Old Municipal Building in Poblacion, Sindangan. In April 2026, the campus adopted a blended learning modality as part of austerity measures aimed at conserving fuel resources, with face-to-face classes held Mondays, Tuesdays, and Saturdays at the Misok Campus, and online classes conducted Wednesdays through Fridays via Google Meet and Google Classroom. All examinations remained face-to-face to protect academic integrity.

Academic Structure

The campus is led by the Office of the Campus Director, supported by a Special Assistant to the Campus Director and administrative staff. As of the Second Semester of AY 2025–2026, MSU-MCSE maintained 52 personnel across its academic departments, categorized as follows:

- Organic Faculty (28): hired directly at MSU-MCSE, with salaries funded by the LGU of Sindangan under the MOA
- Organic Faculty with Item (5): originally LGU-funded, now covered under MSU-Main Campus plantilla items
- Mobile Faculty (9): MSU-Main Campus faculty who rotate teaching duties, typically every other week, between Marawi and Sindangan
- Full-Time Faculty (4): MSU-Main Campus faculty whose entire teaching load is dedicated to MSU-MCSE
- Campus Administration and Staff (6): including the Campus Director, Special Assistant, and LGU-assigned administrative personnel

Ten of the faculty members additionally serve as Program Coordinators for their respective degree programs.

Academic Programs and Curriculum Offerings

MSU-MCSE currently offers eleven degree programs:

1. Bachelor of Science in Agricultural and Biosystems Engineering (ABE)
2. Bachelor of Science in Chemical Engineering (CHE)
3. Bachelor of Science in Civil Engineering (CE)
4. Bachelor of Science in Electrical Engineering (EE)
5. Bachelor of Science in Mechanical Engineering (ME)
6. Bachelor of Science in Psychology (PSY)
7. Bachelor of Science in Environmental Science (ES)
8. Bachelor of Science in Fisheries (FIS)
9. Bachelor of Science in Mathematics (MAT)
10. Bachelor of Science in Statistics (STT)
11. Bachelor of Secondary Education Major in Mathematics (BSEd Math), approved May 21, 2026, to begin First Semester, AY 2026–2027

For the Second Semester of AY 2025–2026, Civil Engineering had the highest enrollment among the ten established programs with 126 students, followed by Environmental Science with 109 and Psychology with 103.

Research, Extension, and Community Engagement

Building a culture of research has been a growing priority for the campus. From March 19 to 21, 2026, MSU-MCSE held a 3-Day Reecho Seminar on Research Capacity Building, IDP Integration, and Faculty Research Orientation, helping align faculty research work with the University's Institutional Development Plan. This was followed on May 9, 2026, by a Faculty and Student Research Seminar titled "Foundations of Research in the Age of AI: Building Ethical, Data-Driven, and AI-Assisted Researchers," which tackled research conceptualization, data analysis, ethical AI use, academic writing, and scholarly integrity.

On the community front, the Environmental Envoys and Conservationists Society (EnvironECS), working with the Supreme Student Government (SSG), led a Mangrove Planting Activity in Barangay R.G. Macias, Sindangan, during Earth Month 2026, joined by LGU Sindangan Mayor Hon. Glona G. Labadlabad and various government agencies. The campus also took part in Gabay Zanorte: Division Career Guidance Expo 2026 on March 4, 2026, at the Sindangan Cultural and Sports Complex, where faculty and student leaders guided junior and senior high school learners on higher education pathways.

Student Life and Organizations

Student life at MSU-MCSE runs through bodies like the Supreme Student Government (SSG), which has organized events such as the Month of Love celebration on February 13, 2026, featuring interactive booths, departmental games, and cultural performances. The Environmental Envoys and Conservationists Society (EnvironECS) leads sustainability initiatives such as mangrove planting. Weekly Monday Flag Ceremonies serve as a regular gathering point for announcements, recognitions, and introducing new faculty to the community, as seen on February 9, 2026, when eight newly hired faculty members were formally welcomed.

Traditions and Culture

Founding anniversaries are a big deal at MSU-MCSE. The 5th Founding Anniversary, held March 19 to 23, 2026, featured a torch lighting ceremony, salute performances, cultural presentations, and the introduction of Mr. and Ms. MSU-MCSE 2026 candidates representing four cluster teams: Dauntless, Erudite, Amity, and Candor. The five-day celebration wove together academic, cultural, sports, and student development activities into one big campus-wide affair.

The campus also observes broader civic milestones. In February 2026, it marked the 40th Anniversary of the EDSA People Power Revolution with a screening of the film "Batas Militar," encouraging reflection on democracy, human rights, and responsible citizenship. Meanwhile, the Hard Hatting and Pinning Ceremony has become an annual rite of passage for students from Engineering, Environmental Science, Fisheries, Psychology, Mathematics, and Statistics as they step into apprenticeship, internship, and on-the-job training.

Administration and Governance

MSU-MCSE operates under a Campus Director appointed through a special order from the MSU System, with a six-year term as stipulated in the MOA between the LGU of Sindangan and MSU Main Campus. The Office of the Campus Director (OCD) is supported by a Special Assistant and administrative staff. Governance decisions, particularly on funding, faculty plantilla, and infrastructure, are coordinated through regular dialogue between the MSU System Administration and the LGU of Sindangan, most recently formalized in a Bilateral Meeting held May 14, 2026, which addressed proposed amendments to the MSU-LGU MOA, funding arrangements, faculty plantilla requirements, student assistance programs, and the long-term goal of institutional autonomy for the campus.

Presidents, Chancellors, or Heads

- Dr. Florencio D. Recoleto Jr., PhD: First and current Campus Director of MSU-MCSE, designated in April 2021 with a six-year term
- Prof. Elpidio S. Ricaborda, JD: Special Assistant to the Campus Director
- Atty. Paisalin P.D. Tago, CPA: MSU System President, who made his first official visit to Sindangan and MSU-MCSE from May 13 to 15, 2026
- Dr. Minerva-Saminah M. Naga: Vice President and Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs, who approved the lowering of the SASE cut-off score in May 2026 to expand access to admission

Facilities and Landmarks

The main academic site sits at the Balok campus, with additional operations at the Misok Campus, where the pioneering Flag Raising Ceremony was held in 2021 and where face-to-face classes continue under the current blended learning arrangement. The GAD Building has also been used for face-to-face sessions when needed. Large-scale institutional events, from enrollment to founding anniversary celebrations, are typically held at the Sindangan Cultural and Sports Complex, while the Office of the Campus Director is based at the 2nd Floor of the Old Municipal Building, Poblacion, Sindangan.

Accreditation and Recognition

MSU-MCSE's academic quality has been reflected in a series of licensure examination results. In January 2026, the Department of Psychology and Related Services achieved a 100% passing rate in the Certified Human Resource Associate (CHRA) Assessment Examination, with all nine examinees passing, placing the campus among the top-performing schools in the country for that exam. The campus's first batch of BS Fisheries graduates achieved an 85.71% passing rate in the Fisheries Professional Licensure Examination (FPLE), well above the national passing rate of 69.61%. In the April 2026 Registered Electrical Engineers Licensure Examination, MSU-MCSE posted a 100% passing rate among its four examinees. Engr. Aaron O. Mateo became the campus's first Civil Engineering Licensure Examination passer in March–April 2026, while Engr. Joscel Ijurpe became its first Registered Chemical Engineer after passing the 2026 Chemical Engineer Licensure Examination.

Significant Milestones

- July 23, 2020: Formal letter sent to MSU System President initiating discussions on the extension campus
- March 22, 2021: MSU Board of Regents approves the creation of MSU-MCSE
- April 8, 2021: MOA signed between LGU Sindangan and MSU Main Campus
- September 8-9, 2021: First Flag Raising Ceremony and official inauguration
- March 22, 2025: 4th Founding Anniversary
- July 4, 2025: First Pre-Commencement Exercises, 113 pioneering graduates
- January 2026: 100% passing rate in the CHRA Assessment Examination
- March 4, 2026: Participation in Gabay Zanorte Division Career Guidance Expo
- March 19-21, 2026: Research Capacity Building and IDP Integration Seminar
- March 19-23, 2026: 5th Founding Anniversary
- April 6, 2026: Implementation of austerity measures and blended learning modality
- April 26, 2026: MSU College Entrance Test (CET) 2026 administered, 212 examinees
- May 4, 2026: MSU SASE results released; October 2025 exam produced 210 initial passers
- May 9, 2026: Faculty and Student Research Seminar on AI-assisted research
- May 13-15, 2026: First official visit of MSU System President Atty. Paisalin P.D. Tago, CPA
- May 14, 2026: 3rd Crème de la Crème Recognition Program and Bilateral Meeting between MSU System and LGU Sindangan
- May 20, 2026: SASE cut-off score lowered from 80 to 69, raising qualified enrollees to 408
- May 21, 2026: Approval of the Bachelor of Secondary Education Major in Mathematics, the campus's 11th degree program
- May 28, 2026: 3rd Hard Hatting and Pinning Ceremony

Notable Alumni

- Engr. Aaron O. Mateo: First Civil Engineering Licensure Examination passer from MSU-MCSE, Batch Lawig
- Engr. Joscel Ijurpe, RChE: First Registered Chemical Engineer produced by MSU-MCSE
- Engr. Jahnvi R. Macatipon, Engr. Clifford Khims H. Jungoy, Engr. Joseph E. Tulabing, and Engr. Ernie Kemp D. Rongo: Achieved a 100% passing rate in the April 2026 Registered Electrical Engineers Licensure Examination
- Chessa Mae Sofia S. Amahan, Rems B. Andagan, Ronnie B. Bandibas Jr., Mikaela E. Pingkian, James Anderson A. Ramilo, and Von Deansel O. Tapales: Registered Fisheries Professionals from the campus's first BS Fisheries graduating batch
- Danfe Lean Grace R. Elopre: First President's Lister of MSU-MCSE, recognized during the 3rd Crème de la Crème Recognition Program

Notable Faculty

- Dr. Florencio D. Recoleto Jr., PhD: Campus Director and former Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs of MSU Main Campus
- Prof. Elpidio S. Ricaborda, JD: Special Assistant to the Campus Director
- Prof. Anna Rose B. Pilapil, PhD: Senior Fisheries faculty, known for her inspirational message at the 3rd Hard Hatting and Pinning Ceremony
- Sharifah A. Galvez, RFP: Faculty member and Registered Fisheries Professional

Contributions to Education, Society, and the Bangsamoro Community

As an extension of the Mindanao State University System, MSU-MCSE carries forward MSU's founding mandate to serve Muslim and Indigenous communities across the MINSUPALA region, while also opening opportunities to the wider Subanen and general population of Zamboanga del Norte. By keeping tuition and testing fees free and lowering admission barriers where possible (as seen in the 2026 SASE cut-off score adjustment), the campus has made higher education genuinely reachable for families in Sindangan and neighboring towns who might otherwise have had to send their children far from home to study. Its growing list of licensed professionals, engineers, fisheries specialists, and psychology-related practitioners, is already feeding back into the local workforce and economy of the Zamboanga Peninsula.

Legacy and Impact

In just five years, MSU-MCSE has gone from an idea floated in a casual conversation between local leaders and MSU officials to a campus of nearly 800 students, eleven degree programs, and a growing track record of board exam passers. Its story reflects what can happen when local government units, university administrators, and community leaders align around a shared goal: accessible, quality education for a region that needed it. As the campus continues pursuing its long-term goal of institutional autonomy, it remains anchored to the same vision that started it all, bringing MSU's mission of inclusive, transformative higher education closer to the people of Sindangan and the entire Zamboanga Peninsula.

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